again, Gen Rawat gave me no hint of what was in store. The Combined Commanders' Conference, a tri-service conference of all the Chiefs and all the Army Commander equivalents of the three services, was scheduled for the end of August at Jodhpur, which the Prime Minister would attend. The orders came barely a week or so before that. I rushed back after the Conference on 30 August and drove up from Chandigarh to Shimla at night. On the 31st, I completed all the formalities and was given a farewell lunch, after which we drove down to Chandigarh for the night, having spent exactly nine months in Shimla. Veena had to do all the packing in my absence, something she had become an expert at. The next morning, we were on a flight bound for Kolkata. My friends in Shimla were most upset, especially Raja Bhasin, who was working feverishly on the play. This would be my seventh posting to Eastern Command beginning from the first one as a 2/Lt bound for Gangtok. Would it be Lucky Seven?

On the flight to Kolkata, I thought about my tenure at ARTRAC. Pushing myself, I had managed to visit as many as twenty-five out of the thirty-two training establishments under ARTRAC. But had these visits achieved anything, or were the changes only cosmetic? What I realized was that there needed to be continuity. ARTRAC could not become a lay-over before moving to an operational command. To do justice to such a command spread over the whole of India, a full tenure of at least a year and a half was essential. This round-robin shuffling had to stop.

I was no stranger to Kolkata or to the Command HQ situated at Fort William, having been there many times since my days as a Brigadier at Phulbari. Fort William was built between 1758 and 1781 by Robert Clive, after the Battle of Plassey, on the Eastern banks of the Hooghly River. Just inside the main

Copyright © Penguin Random House India Not for circulation